

TIAGO DA CUNHA FERRÃO

Innovation Director · Deep Hybrid Manager
Engineering · Data Science · AI · Strategy

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EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

Hybrid manager with a STEM foundation and 20+ years of innovation leadership across R&D, EU-funded programmes, and digital transformation — combining environmental engineering, business management, innovation management, and data science. Currently Innovation Director at AdP VALOR, the innovation and shared services arm of Águas de Portugal Group, where a small team orchestrates a ~€1M/year program of new innovation projects across all group operating companies — selection, execution control, payments, and reporting — with project teams embedded at each operating company. Experienced in implementing innovation culture, aligning it with corporate strategy, and scaling AI and automation across organizations. National representative for innovation management methodology — ISO TC 279 WG3 (Tools and Methods), Portuguese Technical Commission 169 (R&D&I), IPAC accreditation expert for Innovation Management Systems, and European Innovation Council Expert Evaluator. Invited Professor for International Innovation Management at ISCTE Executive Education. Executive Master's in Innovation Management, with specialist training in data science at Lisbon Data Science Academy.

CORE COMPETENCIES

- Innovation Strategy, Portfolio Management & Multi-Year Roadmap
- Innovation Operating Models, Processes, Policies & Governance for Multi-Entity Groups
- Lean Innovation Processes & Data-Driven Process Design
- AI, GenAI & Intelligent Automation Deployment (Python, MCP, agentic workflows)
- Modern Stack Integration: ERP, Collaboration & Innovation Tools
- Business Case Construction & Financial Modelling — Multi-Scale (M&A to Pilot) with Assumption Validation
- M&A Due Diligence — Legal, Financial & Technical (high-value transactions)
- Public & Private Procurement (PT, EU & B2B Contracting)
- Team Building & Talent Strategy
- Innovation Methodology: Lean Startup (Ries), Agile, Design Thinking, ISO 56000 series
- Cross-Border Operations (Portugal, Italy, UK, EU)

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

Innovation Director · AdP VALOR — Grupo Águas de Portugal 2022 – Present · Lisbon, PT
Innovation and shared services arm of Águas de Portugal Group; serves all group operating companies.

- Designed and operate the innovation teams from the ground up — covering five activity areas (Strategic, Operational, Open, Product Development, and R&D), including governance, methodology, KPIs, and multi-horizon roadmaps (short-, medium-, and long-term).
- Partner with process owners across AdP Group operating companies to assess end-to-end processes, prioritize interventions across simplification, standardization, automation, and AI, and lead implementation through to adoption and measurable cycle-time and cost outcomes.
- Designed and run an internal innovation competition that adds ~€1M of R&D and innovation projects to the AdP Group portfolio each year since 2022, with supporting business cases and financial models.
- Embed AI and automation directly into operations — Python pipelines, Notion-connected agents, MCP integrations — driving performance gains across innovation portfolio management, operations, and processes.
- Built and lead the innovation teams' talent strategy — designed the competency framework, selection methodology, and onboarding for senior and specialist hires; track record of strong placements that have shaped the team's culture.

Invited Professor — International Innovation Management · 2023 – Present · Lisbon, PT
ISCTE Executive Education

- Teach innovation management in international corporate environments within the International Management Master's programme — covering methodology, governance, data-driven decision-making, and innovation's impact on corporate competitiveness and performance.

Innovation Manager · SmartEnergyLab (EDP's CoLAB)

2021 – 2022 · Lisbon, PT

National Collaborative Laboratory for Energy Transition.

- Implemented Eric Ries' Lean Startup methodology across the lab's energy transition project portfolio, by explicit mandate.
- Built innovation governance, technology validation pipeline, and methodology framework for the lab's R&D-to-market translation work.
- Designed and implemented a strategic intelligence methodology — monitoring technology, competitors, market trends, and signals — to inform the commercial strategy of a major national utility.

Co-Founder · SPORTSPOTS & Ready2innov

2018 – 2021 · Lisbon, PT

- Co-founded two ventures over three years: SPORTSPOTS (digital sports platform startup; subject of ISCTE Master's dissertation) and Ready2innov (innovation consultancy serving Portuguese and international clients).
- Built MVPs, business plans, investor pitches, product validation, go-to-market strategies, and methodology frameworks — spanning consumer-tech entrepreneurship and B2B innovation advisory.
- SPORTSPOTS was selected by the KickUP Sports Accelerator — the first European sports accelerator launched within a major sports club, in partnership with SL Benfica — and won recognition across multiple startup competitions.

Innovation Expert · IPAC — Portuguese Accreditation Institute

2017 – 2021 · Lisbon, PT

- National Accreditation Expert for Innovation Management Systems (ISO 56002 / NP 4457).
- Audited and evaluated Portuguese auditors in innovation management certification; contributed to national accreditation methodology and represented Portugal in ISO working groups for the 56000 family of standards.

Innovation Policy Manager · CEiiA

2016 – 2018 · Matosinhos / Lisbon, PT

- Led inter-institutional innovation policy initiatives and EU-funded mobility R&D programs at one of Portugal's leading mobility and aerospace innovation centres.

Energy Program Manager · INTELI — Inteligência em Inovação

2012 – 2016 · Lisbon, PT

- Developed a nationwide digital platform for biomass resources mapping and management, with significant technical sophistication.
- Led a multinational research project on local energy strategies (published in WIT Transactions on Ecology and the Environment, 2014).

Business Development · Lanco Solar International

2011 – 2012 · Milan / London

- Led business development in Italy for UK-headquartered Lanco Solar International — running due diligence, deal assessment, and complex commercial negotiations on utility-scale solar PV transactions.

Deputy Country Manager · Martifer Renewables

2008 – 2011 · Lisbon, PT / Rome, IT

After role as International Business Manager in Lisbon (2008–2009).

- Drove international business development from headquarters — analysing renewable project pipelines across the Mediterranean, supporting the build-up of Martifer's Italian and Greek operations.
- Built market intelligence and deal-screening processes that fed the country teams during the peak of the European renewables boom.
- Conducted M&A due diligence on PV and wind plant acquisitions and land deals — across legal, financial, and technical dimensions, on complex transactions during peak Italian renewables sector activity.
- Ran the Italian subsidiary as a lean two-person operation, closing high-value deal packages and managing stakeholder relationships across municipalities, grid operators, and financial counterparties.

Environmental Technician · Sonae Sierra

2005 – 2008 · Milan, IT / Lisbon, PT

Global EMS Shared Services Delivery

After role as International Intern in Milan (2005–2006).

- Implemented environmental standards and procedures across the Italian shopping centre portfolio.
- Returned to Portuguese headquarters to deliver environmental compliance and EMS services to Sonae Sierra shopping centres worldwide — final year inside a mature global shared services operating model.

Junior Consultant · Enerdinâmica

2004 – 2005 · Lisbon, PT

- Designed strategic plans for energy neutrality — covering zero-carbon and low-carbon transitions, emissions reduction roadmaps, and broader sustainability strategy.

Junior Researcher · DEECA — INETI

2002 – 2004 · Lisbon, PT

- Applied research at Portugal's national engineering and industrial technology institute. Operated a fluidized bed reactor for the safe incineration of meat-and-bone meal potentially contaminated with BSE (mad cow disease), and monitored dioxin emissions in the exhaust during the peak European BSE crisis.

EDUCATION

Engineering & Natural Sciences

- Graduate Degree in Environmental Engineering — University of Aveiro

Economics & Policy

- Postgraduate in Energy and Environment Politics and Economics — ISEG

Business & Innovation Management

- Master's in Business Management and Administration — ISCTE
- Executive Master's in Management with Specialization in Innovation — INDEG (ISCTE Executive Education)

Data Science & Information Technology

- PhD Candidate in Information Technology — NOVA IMS. Subject: Data-Driven Innovation
- Lisbon Data Science Academy — Batch #5

RECOGNITION & INSTITUTIONAL ROLES

- Member, ISO TC 279 — Innovation Management, Working Group 3 (Tools and Methods)
- Member, Technical Commission 169 (CT 169) at IPQ — Portuguese Standardization Body, for Research, Development and Innovation Activities
- National Accreditation Expert for Innovation Management Systems — IPAC
- Expert Evaluator — European Innovation Council (EIC) Programme

PUBLICATIONS

Cosmi, C., Dvarioniene, J., Marques, I., Ferrão, T., Bloomfield, I., Brix, K., & Trummer, D. R. (2014). *Local strategies for competitive, effective and secure energy uses: The RENERGY transfer tools and methods*. WIT Transactions on Ecology and the Environment, 191, 295–304. DOI: 10.2495/SC140251

Ferrão, T. da Cunha (2018). *SportSpots: Business Plan — a business plan adapted for a digital startup*. Master's Dissertation, ISCTE, Lisbon

LANGUAGES

Portuguese (Native) · English (C2 — TOEFL 110/120) · Italian (C2) · French (A1)

ADDITIONAL TRAINING & CERTIFICATIONS

- Data Analysis & Visualization with Python — paths + 12 projects (2022–2025) — Dataquest
- Full Stack Development Bootcamp — Le Wagon
- Energy and Environment Economics — York University
- Environmental Auditing and Environmental Management Systems — Jacques Whitford Institute
- Short Postgraduate in Soil and Plant Data Analysis — Wageningen University (WUR)

OTHER

- Federated competitive swimmer — Portuguese Swimming Federation (FPN); marathon runner.